



PIRLS Reading Practice — Year 5

Providence English Private School

Set 5: Grandma's Recipe Box

Literary Text · 13 Questions · 40 Minutes

Name: _____ Class: _____ Date: _____

Grandma's Recipe Box

Every Sunday afternoon, Priya's grandmother took out the same battered tin box, its lid decorated with faded flowers, and set it on the kitchen table like a small ceremony. Inside were dozens of recipe cards, some so old and stained with use that the handwriting had nearly worn away.

"Today," her grandmother announced, "you learn the samosas."

Priya had eaten her grandmother's samosas her entire life — crisp, golden pastry parcels filled with spiced potato and peas — but she had never actually made them herself. She'd always assumed the recipe was some closely guarded secret, passed down only when a person was ready.

"Is it going to be complicated?" Priya asked, eyeing the box warily.

Her grandmother laughed, a warm sound that filled the small kitchen. "Every recipe seems complicated the first time. That is simply what learning feels like."

She pulled out a card so worn that Priya could barely read the looping handwriting. "This was written by my mother, your great-grandmother, back in a kitchen in Jaipur. I learned from watching her hands, not just from these words. The card only tells you what to do — it can't tell you how the dough should feel between your fingers, or how to know by smell when the spices are ready."

They began with the dough, and Priya quickly discovered her grandmother was right. The recipe card simply said "knead until smooth," but it took several attempts, and several patient corrections from her grandmother, before Priya understood what "smooth" actually meant — a particular softness, a certain way the dough stopped sticking to her fingers.

Making the filling proved trickier still. Priya's grandmother added spices by eye, a pinch here, a small handful there, never once glancing at a measuring spoon.

"How do you know how much to add?" Priya asked, frustrated, after her own attempt tasted flat and underwhelming compared to her grandmother's.

"You taste as you go," her grandmother said simply, holding out a small spoonful of the filling for Priya to try. "Your tongue will tell you what your eyes and the recipe card cannot."

Priya tasted, adjusted, tasted again. Slowly, gradually, something shifted — the flavour began to taste less like her attempt and more like the samosas she remembered from every Sunday of her childhood.

By the time they finished folding and frying the samosas, the kitchen was warm with the smell of spices and hot oil, and Priya's hands ached in a way that felt strangely satisfying. Her first attempts were lopsided, with filling occasionally escaping through poorly sealed edges, but her grandmother only smiled at each imperfect one.

"Your great-grandmother's first ones probably looked worse than these," she said. "Recipes aren't really about getting it perfect immediately. They're about a person choosing to pass something on, and someone else choosing to catch it."

That evening, as Priya bit into one of her own slightly misshapen samosas, she noticed something she hadn't expected: it tasted, unmistakably, like home. Not exactly like her grandmother's — not yet — but close enough that she understood, for the first time, what she'd actually been given that afternoon. It wasn't only a recipe. It was a small piece of her family that she could now carry forward herself, one imperfect samosa at a time.

Questions

1. MULTIPLE CHOICE · RETRIEVE

What does Priya's grandmother take out every Sunday afternoon?

- ☐ A A photo album
- ☐ B A tin box of recipe cards
- ☐ C A cookbook
- ☐ D A box of old letters

2. MULTIPLE CHOICE · RETRIEVE

What food does Priya learn to make in this story?

- ☐ A Bread
- ☐ B Samosas
- ☐ C Cake
- ☐ D Curry

3. WRITTEN RESPONSE · INFER

Why had Priya never made samosas herself before this day, even though she had eaten them her whole life?

4. MULTIPLE CHOICE · RETRIEVE

Who originally wrote the samosa recipe card?

- ☐ A Priya's grandmother
- ☐ B Priya's great-grandmother
- ☐ C Priya herself
- ☐ D A cookbook author

5. WRITTEN RESPONSE · INTERPRET & INTEGRATE

According to the grandmother, what can't a recipe card tell you, even if you follow it exactly? Explain using her own words or ideas from the text.

6. MULTIPLE CHOICE · RETRIEVE

How does Priya's grandmother measure spices for the filling?

- ☐ A Using precise measuring spoons
- ☐ B By eye and by taste, without exact measurements
- ☐ C By following the recipe card exactly
- ☐ D She doesn't add any spices

7. MULTIPLE CHOICE · INTERPRET & INTEGRATE

What does the grandmother mean when she says, 'Your tongue will tell you what your eyes and the recipe card cannot'?

- ☐ A Priya should stop reading the recipe entirely
- ☐ B Tasting the food is the best way to judge if the seasoning is right
- ☐ C The recipe card is completely wrong
- ☐ D Priya has a better sense of taste than her grandmother

8. WRITTEN RESPONSE · INTERPRET & INTEGRATE

How does Priya's understanding of the word 'smooth' change over the course of making the dough? Why does this happen?

9. MULTIPLE CHOICE · RETRIEVE

What happens to some of Priya's first samosas while frying?

- ☐ A They burn completely
- ☐ B Filling escapes through poorly sealed edges
- ☐ C They turn out perfectly on the first try
- ☐ D They are too small to eat

10. MULTIPLE CHOICE · RETRIEVE

What is the grandmother's attitude toward Priya's imperfect samosas?

- ☐ A Disappointed and critical
- ☐ B Encouraging, noting even her own mother's first attempts were likely worse
- ☐ C Indifferent, she doesn't comment at all
- ☐ D Annoyed that Priya didn't follow instructions exactly

11. WRITTEN RESPONSE · EVALUATE

What do you think the grandmother means when she says recipes are 'about a person choosing to pass something on, and someone else choosing to catch it'?

12. MULTIPLE CHOICE · INTERPRET & INTEGRATE

What does Priya realise about the samosa she eats at the end of the story?

- ☐ A It tastes nothing like her grandmother's
- ☐ B It tastes unmistakably like home, even though it isn't perfect
- ☐ C It is too spicy to eat
- ☐ D It tastes exactly identical to her grandmother's

13. WRITTEN RESPONSE · EVALUATE

What is the deeper meaning or theme of this story, beyond just learning to cook? Support your answer with evidence from the text.

Answer Key & Model Answers

1. B — A tin box of recipe cards

The passage describes the 'battered tin box' containing recipe cards, taken out every Sunday.

2. B — Samosas

The grandmother announces they will make samosas at the start of the passage.

3. Written response

Model answer: Priya had assumed the recipe was a closely guarded secret only passed down when someone was ready, so she never had the opportunity or thought to ask to learn it before.

Marking guidance: Full credit: references her assumption about the recipe being a guarded secret. Partial credit: gives a vague reason without textual support.

4. B — Priya's great-grandmother

The grandmother explains the card was written by her mother, Priya's great-grandmother, in Jaipur.

5. Written response

Model answer: A recipe card can't tell you how the dough should actually feel between your fingers or how to know by smell when the spices are ready — those things can only be learned through experience and practice, not written instructions.

Marking guidance: Full credit: identifies at least one of the sensory/experiential things (feel of dough, smell of spices) mentioned in the text. Partial credit: says 'it can't teach everything' without specifics.

6. B — By eye and by taste, without exact measurements

The passage states she adds spices 'by eye,' never using a measuring spoon.

7. B — Tasting the food is the best way to judge if the seasoning is right

This means that tasting as you cook reveals things that reading a recipe or looking at the food cannot.

8. Written response

Model answer: At first Priya doesn't understand what 'smooth' dough actually means from the recipe card alone, but after several attempts and her grandmother's corrections, she learns to recognise the particular softness and texture by feel — something that could only be learned through hands-on practice, not from words on a card.

Marking guidance: Full credit: explains the shift from not understanding to understanding through practice/correction. Partial credit: says she eventually understood without explaining how or why.

9. B — Filling escapes through poorly sealed edges

The passage states her attempts were lopsided, with filling occasionally escaping through poorly sealed edges.

10. B — Encouraging, noting even her own mother's first attempts were likely worse

The grandmother smiles and reassures Priya that her great-grandmother's first attempts were probably worse too.

11. Written response

Model answer: She likely means that a recipe is more than just instructions for food — it represents a connection between generations, a piece of family history and love that is only kept alive when someone is willing to teach it and someone else is willing to learn and carry it forward.

Marking guidance: Full credit: interprets the metaphor as being about tradition, connection, or family heritage being passed between generations. Partial credit: gives a literal interpretation about cooking without the deeper meaning.

12. B — It tastes unmistakably like home, even though it isn't perfect

The passage says it tasted 'unmistakably, like home,' even though it wasn't exactly like her grandmother's yet.

13. Written response

Model answer: Beyond cooking, the story is about how family traditions, love, and identity are passed down through generations — shown through the three generations of women connected by this recipe, and Priya's realisation at the end that she has received 'a small piece of her family' she can now carry forward herself.

Marking guidance: Full credit: identifies the theme of family/heritage/tradition being passed down, with supporting textual evidence. Partial credit: identifies a surface-level theme (e.g., 'practice makes perfect') without connecting to family/heritage.